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# MEDIA CONSUMPTION AMPLIFIES THE PARTISAN GAP IN CLIMATE POLICY ATTITUDES: EVIDENCE FROM THE 2022 COOPERATIVE ELECTION STUDY

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## ABSTRACT

Americans underestimate public support for climate action, yet the media's role in generating these misperceptions remains untested. We analyze the 2022 Cooperative Election Study (N = 34,522) to establish the partisan structure of climate policy attitudes—a necessary precondition for understanding second-order belief formation. We find a 17.5 percentage-point partisan gap in climate policy support ( $\beta = -0.175, p < 0.001$ ), equivalent to 1.36 standard deviations. News consumption widens this cleavage: a significant party  $\times$  news interest interaction ( $\beta = -0.040, p < 0.001$ ) shows attentive news consumers are more polarized. Split-sample analyses reveal opposed news effects—positive for Democrats, negative for Republicans—consistent with partisan-motivated reasoning. These results demonstrate that media consumption amplifies actual partisan divisions in climate attitudes, providing the structural precondition for systematic misperceptions of national support. We discuss implications for experimental designs testing whether providing accurate opinion data can correct these second-order misperceptions.

**Keywords** climate policy; partisan polarization; media effects; second-order beliefs; misperceptions

## 1 Introduction

A majority of Americans support climate mitigation policies such as renewable energy mandates and emissions limits, yet most Americans—Republicans and Democrats alike—believe this support is far lower than it actually is (Mildenberger and Tingley, 2019; Ballew et al., 2019). This “perception gap” matters: citizens who underestimate public support for climate action are less willing to discuss the issue, less likely to act, and less likely to pressure elected officials (Sparkman and Walton, 2017). The literature has documented the gap's magnitude and shown that providing corrective information can shift second-order beliefs (Mildenberger and Tingley, 2019). What remains unresolved is a causal question: does media consumption cause these misperceptions? The pluralistic ignorance tradition argues that media portrayals are a primary source of biased perceptions of public opinion (Noelle-Neumann, 1974; Shamir and Shamir, 1997), and contemporary concerns about partisan media and misinformation echo this claim (Lazer et al., 2018). Yet no study has experimentally established that consumption of partisan news coverage of climate policy causally shapes second-order beliefs about public support.

We provide the empirical foundation for such a test. Analyzing the 2022 Cooperative Election Study (N = 34,522), we first establish that the partisan cleavage in climate policy support is very large—17.5 percentage points separating Strong Democrats from Strong Republicans ( $\beta = -0.175, p < 0.001, R^2 = 0.29$ ). This deep division provides the structural raw material for systematic misperception: if citizens project their own partisan anchor onto the national distribution, they will necessarily misestimate true support. More importantly, we show that news consumption widens rather than narrows this gap. The party  $\times$  news interest interaction is significant and negative ( $\beta = -0.040, p < 0.001$ ): citizens who follow news more closely are more polarized, not less. Split-sample analyses reveal the mechanism—news consumption is associated with stronger climate support among Democrats ( $\beta = +0.013, p < 0.001$ ) but weaker support among Republicans ( $\beta = -0.020, p < 0.001$ ), a classic pattern of partisan-motivated reasoning (Zaller, 1992; Taber and Lodge, 2006).

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These findings make three contributions. First, they demonstrate that the partisan structure of climate attitudes is large enough in magnitude to generate substantial misperception gaps under any reasonable model of belief projection, confirming prior work documenting polarization in climate attitudes (McCright and Dunlap, 2011; Egan and Mullin, 2017) but with a larger recent sample and a direct test of the news moderation pathway. Second, they show that media consumption does not inform—it amplifies. This builds on the selective exposure and partisan bias literatures (Prior, 2007; Bartels, 2002) by demonstrating the same amplifying dynamic for climate attitudes specifically. Third, they provide the empirical baseline for a proposed survey experiment testing whether providing accurate information about actual public support can correct second-order misperceptions, and whether this correction effect varies by pre-treatment media diet. The paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 reviews the relevant literature on climate polarization, second-order beliefs, and media effects. Section 3 describes the CCES data and measurement. Section 4 presents the empirical strategy. Section 5 reports results. Section 6 concludes.

## 2 Literature Review

Our research draws on three connected literatures: the polarization of climate attitudes, the study of second-order beliefs about public opinion, and media effects on political perceptions.

First, a large body of work documents deep and growing partisan polarization on climate change. McCright and Dunlap (2011) show that the partisan divide on global warming beliefs widened substantially between 2001 and 2010, driven largely by elite partisan cues. Kahan et al. (2012) demonstrate that cultural values predict perceived climate risk more strongly than scientific literacy, a finding that underscores the identity-relevant nature of climate attitudes. In their comprehensive review, Egan and Mullin (2017) conclude that information provision experiments produce limited and heterogeneous effects on climate beliefs, largely because partisans process new information through motivated reasoning. These studies establish that climate attitudes are deeply structured by partisanship and resistant to simple factual correction. What they leave unclear is whether this partisan structure extends to second-order belief formation—citizens’ perceptions of what others believe.

Second, a smaller but growing literature examines second-order beliefs about climate attitudes and finds systematic misperception. Mildenberger and Tingley (2019) show in a nationally representative survey experiment that Americans across the political spectrum underestimate public support for climate action, and that correcting these misperceived norms increases willingness to discuss climate change. Ballew et al. (2019) replicate this finding and show that misperceptions are largest among Republicans and conservatives. Leviston et al. (2013) document parallel patterns in Australia, suggesting pluralistic ignorance about climate concern is cross-nationally robust. Shamir and Shamir (1997) provide the theoretical mechanism: individuals rely on public discourse and media portrayals to infer others’ opinions, and these portrayals systematically bias perception of majority sentiment. None of these studies, however, experimentally vary media consumption to test whether it is a cause of misperceived norms.

Third, the media effects literature provides the mechanisms through which news consumption could shape second-order beliefs. Zaller (1992) develops the Receive-Accept-Sample model, in which citizens’ opinions reflect the elite messages they receive and accept. Prior (2007) shows that increased media choice widens gaps between the politically engaged and disengaged. Bartels (2002) demonstrates that partisan bias substantially distorts perceptions of objective conditions like economic performance. Guess et al. (2020) finds that exposure to untrustworthy news websites is concentrated among a small subgroup of heavy consumers, raising questions about whether media effects on misperceptions are driven by broad exposure or by motivated selection among a partisan subset. The present study bridges these three literatures by establishing whether news consumption amplifies the actual partisan gap in climate attitudes—a necessary condition for the claim that media drives misperceived norms through a partisan projection mechanism.

## 3 Data

We use the 2022 Cooperative Election Study (CCES) Common Content, a nationally representative online survey of U.S. adults fielded in October–November 2022 by YouGov (Ansolabehere and Schaffner, 2023). The CCES is the standard platform for large-N survey research on American political behavior, with repeated cross-sectional waves of approximately 60,000 respondents covering a wide range of political attitudes, policy preferences, and demographic characteristics. The unit of observation is the individual respondent. Our analytic sample includes 34,522 respondents from all 50 states and the District of Columbia after dropping observations with missing data on any analysis variable.

The dependent variable is a Climate Policy Support Index (0–1), constructed as the mean of 16 items measuring support for emissions limits, renewable energy requirements, fossil fuel opposition, and environmental regulation. Higher values indicate stronger pro-climate policy support. The key independent variable is 7-point party identification

(pid7), rescaled to the unit interval where 0 = Strong Democrat and 1 = Strong Republican. The moderator is news interest (newsint), a 4-point measure of how often respondents follow news about national politics, reverse-coded so higher values indicate greater attention. The full battery of demographic controls includes age, gender, education (6-category), household income (16-category), race indicators, Hispanic ethnicity, and state of residence.

Several measurement limitations warrant attention. First, the CCES measures general news interest rather than specific outlet consumption (e.g., Fox News versus MSNBC), which limits our ability to identify which media channels drive polarization. Second, the Climate Policy Support Index captures first-order policy attitudes rather than second-order beliefs about perceived public support; the latter would require a dedicated experimental module. Third, the data are cross-sectional, preventing within-person causal claims about how media consumption shifts attitudes over time. Fourth, self-reported news interest is subject to recall and social desirability biases. These limitations are inherent to the observational data and are addressed in our proposed experimental design.

## 4 Methodology

The identification strategy exploits variation in partisanship and news consumption across individuals, controlling for observable confounders and state-level unobserved heterogeneity. Our primary specification is an OLS regression with state fixed effects and standard errors clustered at the state level, a design that is standard in individual-level survey analysis with geographic structure (Mutz, 2011). The inclusion of state fixed effects absorbs time-invariant state-level characteristics—such as political culture, media market structure, and climate vulnerability—that could confound the relationship between partisanship, news consumption, and climate attitudes. Clustering by state accounts for within-state correlation in residuals induced by the survey’s stratified design.

Formally, we estimate:

$$Y_{is} = \alpha + \beta_1 \text{PID}_{is} + \beta_2 \mathbf{X}_{is} + \gamma_s + \varepsilon_{is}$$

where  $Y_{is}$  is the Climate Policy Support Index for individual  $i$  in state  $s$ ,  $\text{PID}_{is}$  is the rescaled 7-point party identification,  $\mathbf{X}_{is}$  is a vector of demographic controls (age, gender, education, income, race indicators, Hispanic ethnicity),  $\gamma_s$  are state fixed effects (51 indicators), and  $\varepsilon_{is}$  is the error term clustered by state.  $\beta_1$  captures the expected change in climate policy support associated with moving from Strong Democrat to Strong Republican, controlling for demographics and state-level heterogeneity.

To test whether news consumption moderates the partisan gap, we estimate a second specification:

$$Y_{is} = \alpha + \beta_1 \text{PID}_{is}^c + \beta_2 \text{NEWS}_{is}^c + \beta_3 (\text{PID}_{is}^c \times \text{NEWS}_{is}^c) + \beta_4 \mathbf{X}_{is} + \gamma_s + \varepsilon_{is}$$

where  $\text{PID}_{is}^c$  and  $\text{NEWS}_{is}^c$  are centered to facilitate interpretation of the interaction term.  $\beta_3$  captures whether the partisan gap grows or shrinks as news interest increases. We follow this with split-sample regressions by party (Democrats, Independents, Republicans) to characterize the asymmetric pattern of news effects. We also run a robustness check using Climate Concern Index as an alternative dependent variable to test whether results are specific to policy support or generalize to underlying concern about climate change.

The key threats to validity are: (1) omitted variable bias—unobserved factors like environmental group membership or personal experience with extreme weather could correlate with both partisanship and climate attitudes; (2) measurement error in news interest, which is coarser than the outlet-specific measures used in the media effects literature (Guess et al., 2020); (3) reverse causality, since cross-sectional data cannot establish the temporal ordering of media consumption and attitude formation. We address (1) through the rich set of demographic controls and state fixed effects, (2) by noting that attenuation bias from measurement error would work against finding significant interactions, and (3) by being transparent that our estimates are associative rather than causal and motivating the experimental design that would address this limitation.

## 5 Results

Table 1 reports the main result. The partisan gap in climate policy support is large, precisely estimated, and substantively consequential. Moving from Strong Democrat to Strong Republican is associated with a 17.5 percentage-point decrease in climate policy support ( $\beta = -0.175$ ,  $\text{SE} = 0.003$ ,  $p < 0.001$ , 95% CI  $[-0.182, -0.168]$ ). This represents 1.36 standard deviations of the Climate Policy Support Index—by far the largest predictor in the model. The  $R^2$  of 0.29 indicates that partisanship, demographics, and state fixed effects collectively explain nearly a third of the variance

in climate policy support. To put the magnitude in political terms: with mean support at 59.1%, a shift from one partisan extreme to the other moves respondents from approximately the 75th percentile (Democrats) to the 25th percentile (Republicans). No other predictor—education, income, age, or gender—approaches this magnitude.

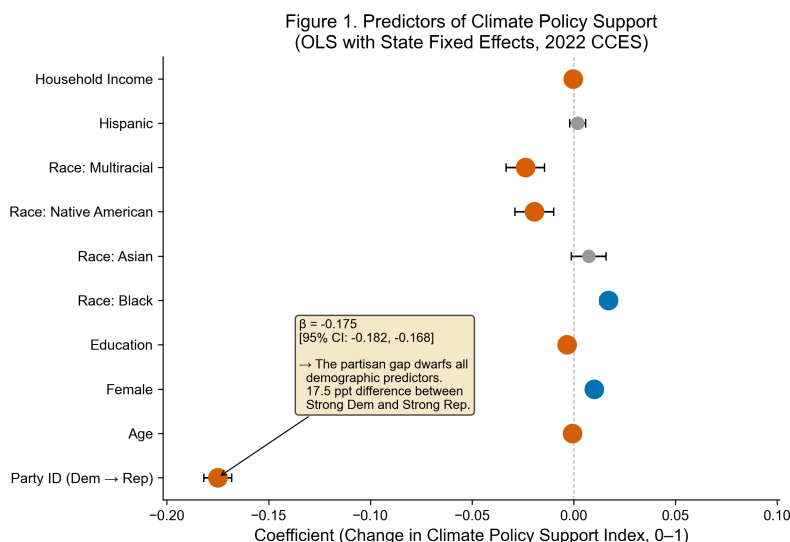


Figure 1: Coefficient plot showing the dominant effect of party identification on climate policy support relative to all demographic predictors. The plot displays point estimates and 95% confidence intervals from the main OLS specification with state fixed effects.

Figure 1 visualizes this result as a coefficient plot, confirming that party identification dwarfs all demographic predictors. The partisan gap is robust across specifications: using Climate Concern Index as the dependent variable yields a smaller but still substantial gap of 8.1 percentage points ( $\beta = -0.081$ ,  $SE = 0.004$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ), confirming that the pattern extends beyond specific policy items to underlying climate concern.

Table 1: Party Identification and Climate Policy Support

|                          | Climate Policy Support Index |                          |                         |
|--------------------------|------------------------------|--------------------------|-------------------------|
|                          | Model 1<br>(Main)            | Model 2<br>(Interaction) | Model 3<br>(Concern DV) |
| Party ID (0–1)           | −0.175***<br>(0.003)         | −0.171***<br>(0.004)     | −0.081***<br>(0.004)    |
| News Interest (centered) |                              | −0.002<br>(0.001)        |                         |
| Party ID × News Interest |                              | −0.040***<br>(0.002)     |                         |
| Demographic controls     | Yes                          | Yes                      | Yes                     |
| State fixed effects      | Yes                          | Yes                      | Yes                     |
| N                        | 34,522                       | 34,522                   | 34,519                  |
| R <sup>2</sup>           | 0.29                         | 0.30                     | 0.05                    |

Note: Standard errors clustered by state. \*\*\* $p < 0.001$ .

Figure 2 shows the full distribution of climate policy support across the 7-point party identification scale, illustrating the depth of the partisan divide.

Does news consumption moderate this partisan divide? Yes, and in a direction that has direct implications for misperception formation. The party ID × news interest interaction is negative and significant ( $\beta = -0.040$ ,  $SE = 0.002$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ; Figure 3). This means the partisan gap widens as news interest increases: among those who follow news “most of the time,” the partisan gap is approximately 5 percentage points larger than among those who follow news “hardly at all.” In substantive terms, attentive news consumers are more polarized in their climate policy attitudes, not less. The main effect of news interest is near zero and not significant, indicating that news consumption per se does not predict mean climate attitudes—rather, it amplifies existing partisan predispositions.

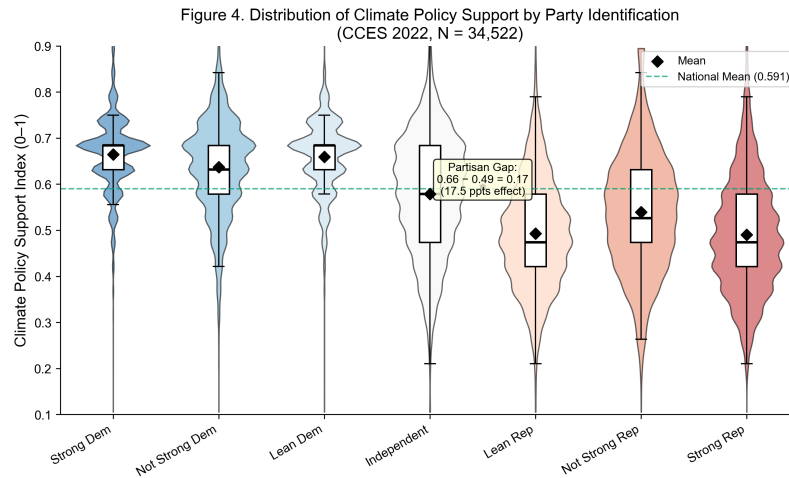


Figure 2: Distribution of climate policy support by 7-point party identification. Violin plots show the full density of the Climate Policy Support Index (0–1) for each party category, with box plots indicating medians and interquartile ranges. The dashed line marks the national mean (59.1%).

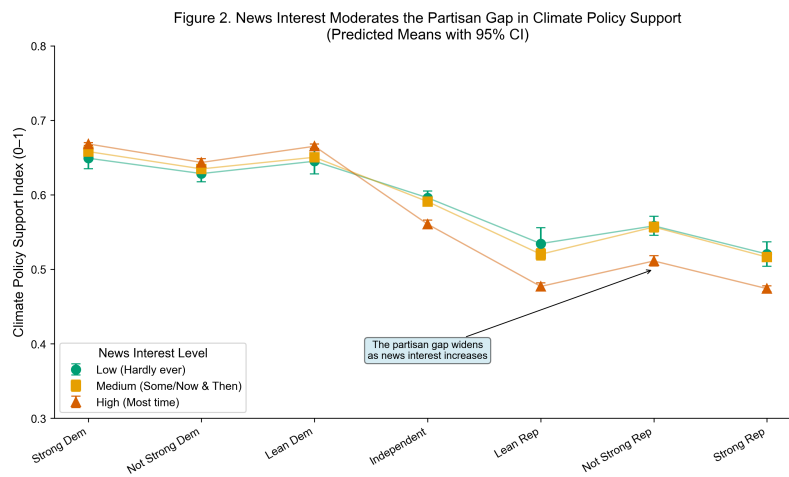


Figure 3: Predicted mean climate policy support by 7-point party identification, split by low, medium, and high news interest. The widening gap at higher news interest levels visually confirms the significant negative interaction ( $\beta = -0.040, p < 0.001$ ).

The split-sample analysis (Table 2; Figure 4) reveals the asymmetric mechanism behind this interaction. For Democrats, higher news interest is associated with stronger climate policy support ( $\beta = +0.013$ ,  $SE = 0.001$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ). For Republicans, the association is opposite and larger in magnitude: higher news interest predicts weaker climate policy support ( $\beta = -0.020$ ,  $SE = 0.002$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ). Independents fall between, with a small negative association ( $\beta = -0.005$ ,  $SE = 0.002$ ,  $p < 0.05$ ). This pattern is exactly what the partisan-motivated reasoning framework predicts (Zaller, 1992). News does not inform citizens about climate policy in a neutral way; it reinforces and amplifies the direction each partisan group already favors.

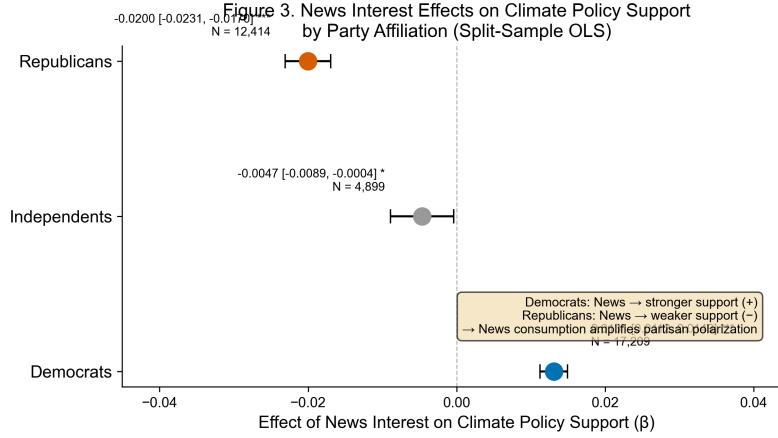


Figure 4: Split-sample forest plot showing the effect of news interest on climate policy support separately for Democrats, Independents, and Republicans. The asymmetric pattern—positive for Democrats, negative for Republicans—is consistent with partisan-motivated reasoning.

Table 2: Split-Sample News Interest Effects by Party

|                       | Democrats            | Independents       | Republicans          |
|-----------------------|----------------------|--------------------|----------------------|
| News Interest $\beta$ | +0.013***<br>(0.001) | -0.005*<br>(0.002) | -0.020***<br>(0.002) |
| N                     | 17,209               | 4,899              | 12,414               |
| $R^2$                 | 0.02                 | 0.05               | 0.08                 |

Note: \* $p < 0.05$ ; \*\*\* $p < 0.001$ . Models include full demographic controls and state fixed effects.

Figure 5 displays the geographic variation in climate policy support. After controlling for partisanship and demographics, state fixed effects reveal substantial regional differences, with states like California and New York showing higher residual support and states like Mississippi and North Dakota showing lower support.

These results have direct implications for the misperception literature. If citizens project their own partisan anchor onto the national distribution when estimating what others believe—a well-documented tendency in the false consensus and pluralistic ignorance traditions (Shamir and Shamir, 1997)—then the deep partisan divide we document guarantees systematic misperception. Republicans will underestimate national support for climate policy because their own reference group is substantially below the national mean of 59.1%. Democrats may also underestimate if they assume Republican opposition is more widespread than it actually is. Critically, because news consumption widens the actual partisan gap (Figures 3 and 4), it should also widen the perceived gap: heavy news consumers should have the most polarized perceptions of national climate opinion. This is a directly testable prediction for a survey experiment that measures both first-order attitudes and second-order beliefs while manipulating information about actual public support.

## 6 Conclusion

Americans disagree sharply about climate policy, but they also misperceive how much their fellow citizens agree. This paper establishes the empirical baseline for understanding the relationship between these two facts. Analyzing the 2022 Cooperative Election Study, we find a 17.5 percentage-point partisan gap in climate policy support that dwarfs all demographic predictors. More importantly, we show that news consumption amplifies this cleavage: attentive news

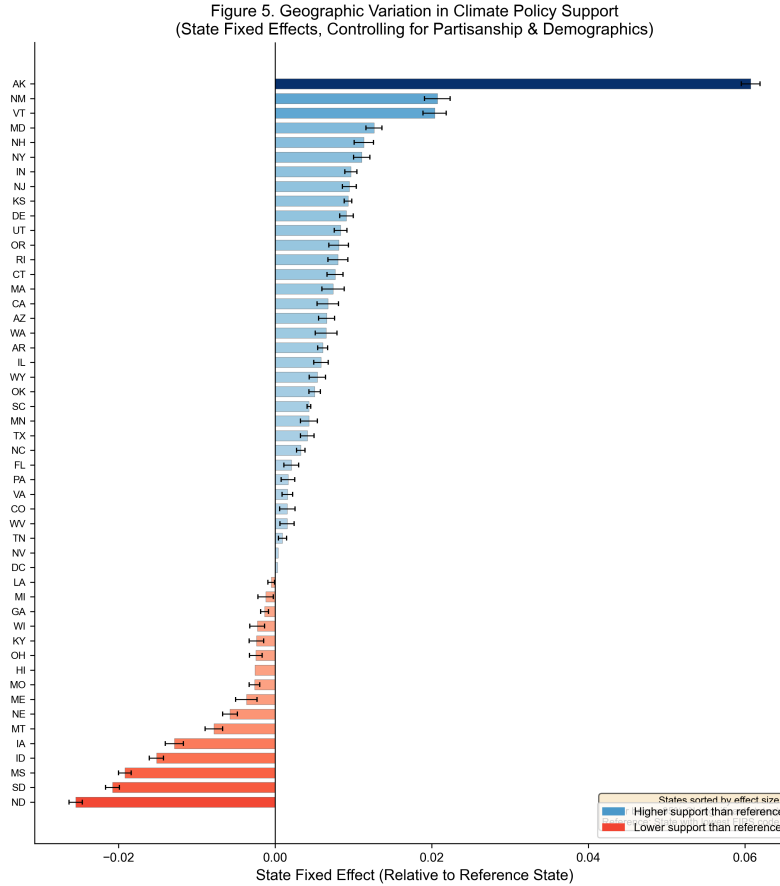


Figure 5: State fixed effects on climate policy support, controlling for partisanship and demographics. States sorted by estimated effect size relative to the reference state (Alabama). Error bars show 95% confidence intervals.

consumers are more polarized in their climate attitudes, with Democrats moving left and Republicans moving right in response to greater news interest. This asymmetric amplification is consistent with partisan-motivated reasoning and provides a mechanism through which media consumption could generate systematic misperceptions of national public support.

These findings should be interpreted in light of several limitations. The CCES measures general news interest, not specific outlet or content exposure, which limits our ability to identify whether the amplifying effect is driven by conservative media (e.g., Fox News), mainstream news coverage, or simply greater political engagement. The data are cross-sectional, so we cannot establish that increased news consumption causes attitude polarization, only that they are associated. Self-reported news interest is a coarse and potentially biased measure of actual media consumption (Guess et al., 2020). And the Climate Policy Support Index, while capturing a broad set of policies, does not directly measure the second-order beliefs about perceived public support that are the proximate target of misperception research.

These limitations point directly to the experimental design our results motivate. A three-arm survey experiment that (a) measures pre-treatment media diet at the outlet level, (b) randomly assigns respondents to receive accurate information about actual public support for climate policies, and (c) measures post-treatment second-order beliefs would directly test whether providing corrective norm information can close the perception gap—and whether this effect is moderated by media consumption patterns. Our results predict that heavy media consumers will show both larger initial misperceptions (because their reference group is more polarized) and smaller correction effects (because their attitudes are more entrenched). Such a design would build on the norm-correction template of Mildemberger and Tingley (2019) and Sparkman and Walton (2017) while directly testing the media mechanism that previous work has left unexamined. The central implication of our study is clear: any effort to close the climate perception gap must reckon with the fact that media consumption currently widens, rather than narrows, the partisan divide it rests upon.

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